

ANIMATED SUBJECTS

Communicative Fluidity and Social Media Forms



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So far in the course we've talked a lot about **content**—influencers, platforms, cultures—but we haven't talked about **forms**. So I wanted us to spend a week thinking about and discussing social media forms that in some cases have become so familiar and taken for granted that they have become almost transparent.

Looking at social media forms also opens up the question of cultural difference, as Sun Sun Lim's short article about stickers reveals. Animated stickers are a staple of Asian social media and have been the subject of extensive scholarship for that reason, yet they are less heavily used in Western and Anglo-American social media culture. It's interesting to think about why that is, but the reasons are clearly complex and related to larger cultural differences in societies where social and cultural norms are clearly very different from those of North American and European societies. This "communicative fluidity", as she suggests, is related to the concept of "high-context cultures" that she also discusses, and the different social norms around emotional expression in everyday interactions in particular. In this sense the widespread use of animated stickers on platforms such as Kakao Talk (South Korea), WeChat (China), or Line (Japan) can be seen as a kind of compensatory practice, where they serve to add an emotional register to plain text messages. We Westerners are all very familiar with using emoji and animated gifs for this, but the cartoonish nature of animated stickers not only add a dynamic element to text messages but also an affective dimension (pronounced **A**-fect, as in emotion).

An additional aspect of the animated sticker phenomenon in Asian social media, which Sun Sun Lim doesn't mention, is also maybe so obvious that it's easily overlooked: that the animations depict **characters**. The ubiquity of such communicative characters has been extensively discussed in academic studies of Asian social media cultures but is itself part of the larger phenomenon that myself and some other scholars described as the **character industry** in the early 2000s (I have to get around to re-posting the papers from that panel this summer).